It was a novel characterisation of a region[27] that had thus far been marginal in the 'Hindu' imagination. Modi was recasting the Northeast as a region with pre-modern cultural linkages to India's old Sanskritic cultures. The influence of these ancient cultures once ranged from 'as far west as Puruşāpura in Gandhāra (Peshawar, in today's northwest Pakistan) to Pāndurānga in Champa (central Vietnam) and Pramambanan on the plains of Java,' wrote the Sanskrit scholar Sheldon Pollock.[28] He famously characterised this vast sphere of Indian cultural influence in the early part of the Common Era as a 'Sanskrit Cosmopolis'.[29] It is telling that Modi's speeches in the Northeast stress on epic connections while simultaneously emphasising the centrality of the region to India's Look-East Policy and the material benefits this would bring. In that sense, if 'the Northeast is seen as the connecting tissue that links parts of the Indian subcontinent with their south-eastern counterparts,' writes the Northeast scholar Arkotong Longkumer, 'then the Northeast has to be "reconstructed" to establish the region as the centre of the "Sanskrit Cosmopolis".'[30] Such ideas lie at the heart of the BJP's new framing of the Northeast as 'Asht-Lakshmi'.

Equally, the BJP's expansion into the Northeast was only possible because the party operates very differently in the region than it does in the Hindi heartland. Within the region, the party followed differentiated and localised growth strategies in each state, based on its specific demographic make-up and historical lineage. It is an adaptability and flexibility that is in contrast to most mainstream depictions of the BJP as a unitary organisation with a highly centralised command and control system. 'The BJP is very flexible as far as Northeast is concerned,' a senior journalist in Guwahati, speaking on condition of anonymity, told me. 'Wherever it has to talk about Vedic religions, it will talk about it, like in Tripura. But elsewhere this doesn't work, in Meghalaya, Nagaland or where there are Christian majorities. There they have a different face. They project themselves there as the champions of the tribal cause and tribal identity. Tribal groups perceive some kind of danger to themselves, especially from the presence of Bengali-speaking Muslims. So, in Nagaland, BJP follows a policy where they look more pro-tribal than anything else, but in Assam their politics is